

THE SUNDAY FORESIGHT

## In four days, Tanzania puts a \$44 insurance policy behind every foreign visitor who lands. Kenya tried to put a \$50,000 one behind every visitor five weeks ago and still can't get it past a judge.

*Both governments reached for the same tool this year. Tanzania's GN 256/2026, gazetted 4 Sep, goes live 1 Oct — \$44 via existing state insurers (NIC mainland, ZIC Zanzibar), 92 days' cover. Kenya's Sh6.4m (~\$50,000) mandate has been frozen by the High Court since 24 Aug; the 16 Sep hearing produced no ruling we can find. Nobody has linked these as one story. Same idea, tested twice in five weeks, opposite results: Tanzania used its insurance regulator and a payable underwriter; Kenya used a single Health Gazette Notice that bypassed the Immigration Act actually governing entry.*

IN THIS ISSUE

|           |                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|-----------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| FORESIGHT | In four days, Tanzania puts a \$44 insurance policy behind every foreign visitor who lands. Kenya tried to put a \$50,000 one behind every visitor five weeks ago and still can't get it past a judge. |
| BIG READ  | East Africa is building rooms faster than it is selling 2027                                                                                                                                           |
| BIG READ  | Kenya's tourism sector just broke a revenue record. Its own tourists couldn't afford to be part of it.                                                                                                 |
| BIG READ  | From Sunday, Europe stops taking East Africa's lodges at their word                                                                                                                                    |
| BIG READ  | AFCON 2027 will be priced, not filled                                                                                                                                                                  |
| BIG READ  | East Africa's hotels no longer set the price of their own staff                                                                                                                                        |
| BIG READ  | Hilton promised owners their margin back. In East Africa, the state decides whether it arrives.                                                                                                        |
| BIG READ  | East Africa knows how wet this season will be. It does not know what its cover is worth.                                                                                                               |
| BIG READ  | The AI agent will book your room. It will still buy it from an OTA.                                                                                                                                    |

**BIG READ** Ethiopia's north went dark in a night. East Africa's exposure is the map, not the airport.

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**BIG READ** Uganda's Ebola all-clear was not an event. It was a queue, and Friday was the first name off it.

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**THE LEDGER** 0 new call(s), 6 resolved

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**NUMBER OF THE WEEK**

**\$44** Tanzania's new mandatory travel-insurance premium per adult, effective 1 Oct 2026 (GN 256/2026).

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Every figure in this issue traces to a named, dated source. Claims are graded Confirmed, Reported or Early signal. Corrections are published, not quietly edited.

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THE SUNDAY FORESIGHT · 27 SEPTEMBER 2026

## In four days, Tanzania puts a \$44 insurance policy behind every foreign visitor who lands. Kenya tried to put a \$50,000 one behind every visitor five weeks ago and still can't get it past a judge.

Both governments reached for the same tool this year. Tanzania's GN 256/2026, gazetted 4 Sep, goes live 1 Oct — \$44 via existing state insurers (NIC mainland, ZIC Zanzibar), 92 days' cover. Kenya's Sh6.4m (~\$50,000) mandate has been frozen by the High Court since 24 Aug; the 16 Sep hearing produced no ruling we can find. Nobody has linked these as one story. Same idea, tested twice in five weeks, opposite results: Tanzania used its insurance regulator and a payable underwriter; Kenya used a single Health Gazette Notice that bypassed the Immigration Act actually governing entry.

### WHAT EVERYONE IS MISSING

: the friction lands unevenly across one itinerary. A guest on the standard Kenya-into-Zanzibar run clears Nairobi and the Mara with no insurance gate, then hits a hard \$44 purchase requirement crossing into Tanzania. Uganda and Rwanda, bound to Kenya inside the East Africa Tourist Visa, have no equivalent. Tanzania sits outside that visa union and moved alone. Not East Africa adopting a norm — the bloc fragmenting on a shared idea, right where itineraries stitch two markets together.

### THE WEEK'S SIGNALS

#### 1 TANZANIA SHIPS THE MANDATE KENYA COULDN'T

GN 256/2026 (4 Sep): \$44 NIC/ZIC insurance mandatory from 1 Oct, entry refusable without it. Kenya's \$50k version stays frozen — no ruling since the 16 Sep hearing (TATO, 26 Sep; Clyde & Co, 16 Sep).

*So what — add the \$44 step to pre-arrival emails for Tanzania/Zanzibar guests now.*

Beach, City, Bush · TZ KE · Confirmed / Inference · impact:margin

#### 2 THE STRIKE WE SAID WOULDN'T HAPPEN, HAPPENED

KAWU struck JKIA two days (30 Aug–1 Sep), voiding our 28 Jul call. The three-week arbitration deadline passed ~22 Sep unresolved (The Star, 1 Sep).

*So what — keep a JKIA-disruption clause in October contracts — the truce is provisional.*

City · KE · Confirmed / Reported · impact:risk

#### 3 THE EU'S GREENWASHING LAW APPLIED TODAY. NO EA BODY SAID A WORD

Directive (EU) 2024/825, barring unverified "eco-friendly" claims, became enforceable EU-wide 27 Sep. No guidance found from KTB, TTB, UTB, RDB, ZCT or the trade bodies (KATO/TATO/AUTO/ZATI/RTTA).

*So what — audit your own EU-facing listing copy — zero local trade-body cover exists.*

Beach, Bush, City · KE UG TZ RW · Reported · impact:watch

#### 4 MOMBASA, NOT NAIROBI, TAKES OCTOBER'S COMPRESSION

Africa MICE Summit moved to 1–2 Oct in Mombasa; Kenya Transport Summit runs 30 Sep–2 Oct at KICC alongside it (africamicesummit.org).

*So what — hold coast rate 30 Sep–2 Oct; keep the dengue/mpox protocol visible.*

City, Beach · KE · Confirmed · impact:demand

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Blind spot: gov.uk KE/UG/RW pages unfetchable (sandbox gate). Scans found no dated Sep change.

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#### 30/90-DAY DEMAND CALENDAR

- TZ** 1 Oct — Tanzania insurance mandate live (GN 256/2026). Brief transiting guests now.
- KE** 30 Sep–2 Oct — Transport Summit + MICE Summit (Mombasa). Hold CBD/coast rate.
- KE** ~15 Oct — EPRA review; fuel-VAT concession lapses 14 Oct — first real pump-price test since June.
- UG** 18 Nov — Uganda Airlines' daily Entebbe–Kigali launch; watch RwandAir's response.
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*Tanzania shipped a \$44 policy in four weeks. Kenya's still can't clear a courtroom after five — what does that say about the next entry rule either writes?*

BIG READ 1 OF 10 · 21 SEPTEMBER 2026

## East Africa is building rooms faster than it is selling 2027

*Nearly 80% of Kenya's hotel pipeline is already concrete, which means it opens whether or not the demand arrives. Last week the 2027 European contracting season opened in Paris, and the Indian Ocean island that turned up was not ours.*

The Seychelles delegation that spent three days at IFTM Top Resa in Paris this month was not large by the standards of a European travel fair, but it was unusually complete. Nine partners stood behind the Seychelles Tourism Board on the stand from 15 to 17 September: four hotel groups in Hilton, Meliá, Raffles and Savoy, three destination management companies in Creole Travel Services, Mason's Travel and 7° South, a specialist operator in Blue Safari, and the national airline. Bernadette Willemin, Special Advisor for Tourism to the Minister for Tourism and Culture, led it in person, alongside the board's Paris market manager, Judeline Edmond.

What Willemin said about why she was there deserves to be read slowly by anyone running a beach property between Diani and Nungwi.

"The 2027 planning cycle is being decided now, and for this market it is decided with the French trade," she said, in comments reported by VoyagesAfriq on 21 September 2026. "Over three days we have been able to listen to the partners who sell Seychelles, understand how they are building their long-haul programmes, and identify where the destination fits within them."

Guillaume Albert, chief executive of Creole Travel Services, was more specific about the outcome. "Several of our major French partners are positioning Seychelles as a strategic destination for 2027 as they look to diversify their long-haul island offering," he said.

Diversify from what, exactly. The set of Indian Ocean islands that a French tour operator can put into a long-haul winter programme is short, and Zanzibar is on it. When a buyer tells a seller they are diversifying, they are describing a reallocation, not an expansion. Somebody's allocation is being moved.

The same week gave Seychelles a second win that is harder to reverse than a brochure position. Condor's weekly nonstop between Frankfurt and the islands became a year-round service, with the first resumed flight landing on 19 September 2026, closing a seasonal gap that had run roughly from mid-May to mid-September. Germany and France are not incidental markets for East African beach stock. They are two of the three European markets that matter most to it. In the space of five days, a competitor destination secured trade positioning in one of them and permanent lift in the other.

East Africa's own September went elsewhere. It went on a Tanzanian gazette notice imposing a US\$44 inbound travel insurance charge, on an electricity pass-through that fell by 54 cents a kilowatt hour, on Canadian and American entry orders tied to an Ebola outbreak in a country none of our five markets border at the point of infection. Every one of those stories was real and every one of them mattered. But notice what they have in common. They are all things done to East African operators by governments, and they are all fought at home. Not one of them was a decision about who sells our rooms next year, and that decision was being taken in a hall in Paris while we were not in it.

Set that against what East Africa has been doing with its capital, because the two facts only become uncomfortable when you put them side by side.

The 2026 Hotel Chain Development Pipelines in Africa report, produced by W Hospitality Group and released on 10 March 2026, counted a record 123,846 rooms across 675 hotels and resorts on the continent, up 18.6% year on year. Egypt dominates the headline volume with 45,984 rooms. But the number that should interest an East

African owner is not the size of the pipeline. It is how much of it has already been poured.

Kenya has 6,190 pipeline rooms across 35 properties, of which 4,922 are under construction. That is 79.5%. Ethiopia sits at 79.9%, Tanzania at 77.5% with 3,222 of 4,159 rooms in the ground. The comparison that gives those figures their meaning is elsewhere on the same table: Nigeria converts at 39.2%, Cape Verde at 8.6%.

Trevor Ward, managing director of W Hospitality Group, read it as a strength. "What stands out this year is the strength of East Africa in terms of projects moving forward," he said when the report was published. "Kenya, Ethiopia and Tanzania show some of the highest construction ratios on the continent, which suggests that this is where we are likely to see new supply coming through in the short to medium term."

He is right, and that is precisely the problem. A pipeline is not a commitment. An announced hotel can be shelved for a year when the market turns, and across Africa a great many are: the report notes that although more than 65,000 rooms are forecast to open in 2026 and 2027, historical actualisation rates suggest delivery will fall short. A hotel at 8.6% conversion is a call option on a market. A hotel at 79.5% conversion is a liability with a completion date. The steel is bought, the contractor is on site, the debt is drawing down and the opening is a scheduling question rather than a strategic one.

The industry has spent six months reading East Africa's construction ratio as a confidence signal. It is at least equally a deadline. Nearly five thousand Kenyan rooms and more than three thousand Tanzanian ones are going to open into 2027 and 2028 whatever the trade decides this autumn, and the trade is deciding this autumn.

The demand side is not keeping the same pace. UN Tourism's latest World Tourism Barometer put global international arrivals up just 0.4% in the first half of 2026, an estimated 690 million travellers, with the full-year forecast cut to between 1% and 2% from an earlier 3% to 4%. Africa led all regions at 4% growth, which is the good news and is genuinely good. It is also growth off a small base, in a year when the global pool of long-haul travellers barely expanded. Africa gaining share in a flat market means Africa took that share from somewhere, and it means the next tranche has to be taken too rather than simply arriving.

This is where the Seychelles story stops being a curiosity about a neighbour and starts being a structural risk, and the person who explains the mechanism best is not a consultant but an operator.

Mohammed Hersi, group director of operations at Pollmans Tours and Safaris, was asked on 20 September why the wider African industry should care what happens to Zanzibar and the Maasai Mara. His answer was about linkage.

"The Maasai Mara is a magnet that pulls people to Kenya. Zanzibar plays a similar role in this part of the region," he said. "People come to the Mara and then add Diani or Zanzibar. Or they come to Zanzibar and add two or three days on safari in the Serengeti or Manyara. The moment these places lose their shine, the pull weakens across the board."

Read that alongside Albert's line about diversifying the long-haul island offering and the shape of the exposure becomes clear. East Africa does not sell beach and bush as separate products to the European trade. It sells a pairing, and the pairing is the defence. A French operator who books a client into Zanzibar has a live commercial reason to sell the Serengeti leg as well. A French operator who books that client into Seychelles has no safari to attach, because Seychelles has none to sell. The substitution does not cost Zanzibar one beach week. It costs Zanzibar one beach week and costs a Tanzanian or Kenyan camp the three nights that used to travel with it.

That is the part that is being missed. The competitive threat to East African beach stock is not priced in beach terms at all. It is priced in bush nights, and it lands on operators who will never see a Seychelles rate card.

Hersi's prescription for Zanzibar was yield rather than volume, and he was blunt about the arithmetic of the building boom. "A 400-room resort means feeding, housing and watering 1,000 people," he said. "Where's the extra water coming from? The electricity? The waste? Get those answers wrong, and Zanzibar tips into overtourism too." His advice was that the island "should sit medium to upper luxury rather than chase mass

numbers, because there is only one Zanzibar."

He is arguing for rate discipline. The supply data argues that rate discipline is about to get much harder to hold, because a market absorbing thousands of contracted rooms has a structural incentive to buy occupancy with price, and the first properties to break usually break in the shoulder.

There are three things worth doing about this before the quarter closes, and they differ by segment.

Beach operators should treat the European trade calendar as a fixed cost rather than a marketing option. IFTM Top Resa has run. WTM Africa 2027 opened buyer applications on 21 September for a fair at the Cape Town convention centre from 7 to 9 April 2027, and Essence of Africa is in Zanzibar next month. If a competitor destination brought its national airline and four hotel brands to Paris and your property sent nobody anywhere, the 2027 allocation question has already been answered and you were not consulted.

Bush and camp operators should ask their inbound agents one direct question this month: what share of your 2027 European safari bookings currently carries a Zanzibar or Diani beach extension, and what is being quoted against it. A shift in that ratio is the earliest available warning, and it will show in an agent's pipeline months before it shows in anybody's arrivals statistics.

City hotels have the least direct exposure and the clearest window. Kenya's conference calendar between now and the middle of October is the densest of the year, and it is a window that closes before the new room stock opens. Hold rate through it.

The rooms are coming. They were decided three years ago by credit committees that are not taking calls now, and 79.5% of them in Kenya are past the point where anyone can change their mind. What is still open is who sells them, and that is being settled this autumn, in Paris and Cape Town and Zanzibar, by people who will make the decision with or without us in the room.

BIG READ 2 OF 10 · 21 SEPTEMBER 2026

## Kenya's tourism sector just broke a revenue record. Its own tourists couldn't afford to be part of it.

*Kenya's tourism earnings hit a record Sh564 billion this year while domestic bed-nights missed target by 600,000, and Rwanda is reporting the same split. For East African operators, the strategy that grows the top line is not the base that fills the shoulder season.*

On 16 September, two tourism stories ran in the Kenyan press within hours of each other, built from the same government release, and neither much acknowledged the other. Business Daily reported that domestic tourism had missed its bed-night target for the year, Kenyan households retreating under the cost of living. Trade titles covering the same release reported that Kenya's tourism sector had just posted a record Sh564 billion in earnings, comfortably ahead of target. Both were true. Read separately, they look like two different sectors. Read together, they are the same sector, and the gap between them is the story.

The State Department for Tourism's own numbers for the financial year to June 2026 show why. International arrivals rose 15.3 per cent, to 2.79 million, up from 2.42 million. Earnings climbed 23 per cent against a Sh529 billion target to land at Sh564 billion, roughly \$4.4 billion at current rates. On any finance ministry's scorecard, that is an outstanding year. Domestic bed-nights, the nights Kenyans themselves book in their own hotels, lodges and coastal resorts, told a different story: 5.1 million against a target of 5.7 million, a shortfall of 600,000 room-nights, and barely above the 5.01 million recorded the year before. Asked why, the department did not reach for a weather excuse or a global shock. It named the cause directly: "inflationary pressures and the impact of the cost of living on disposable income," which left Kenyans taking shorter trips, choosing cheaper rooms, or cancelling the holiday altogether.

That domestic segment matters more to the average East African property than its share of headline revenue suggests. International arrivals cluster in safari high season and the December coastal peak, and they are disproportionately booked into the top tier of camps and beach resorts that dominate press coverage. Domestic and regional guests are what fill a Mombasa hotel's rooms in April, what keeps a Nairobi conference hotel's midweek occupancy above the break-even line, what turns a quiet Tuesday in Naivasha into a functioning one. A three-star coastal property with sixty rooms does not survive on two safari-season months of full international occupancy alone: it survives on the long, unglamorous stretch of weekend getaways, school-holiday family bookings and corporate away-days that domestic demand supplies for the other ten. A sector can hit a record on the back of high-yield international demand while its everyday occupancy base, the one that pays the electricity bill in the low season, quietly erodes. That is what Kenya's own data just described.

The two headline numbers, side by side, make the point better than either does alone.

| Measure                             | FY2025/26 result   | Target             | Change                   |
|-------------------------------------|--------------------|--------------------|--------------------------|
| Tourism earnings                    | Sh564bn (~\$4.4bn) | Sh529bn            | +23.1%                   |
| International arrivals              | 2.79m              | not stated         | +15.3%                   |
| Domestic bed-nights                 | 5.1m               | 5.7m               | +1.8%, missed by 600,000 |
| Middle East arrivals (current base) | 20,480             | KTB target: 50,000 | more than double, sought |

Sources: State Department for Tourism figures as reported by Business Daily Africa and Travel And Tour World, 16 September 2026; Kenya Tourism Board figures as reported by Eastleigh Voice and ATTA, 16 September 2026.

It is also, not coincidentally, the segment the government's growth strategy is not built around. The Kenya Tourism Board is instead chasing the Gulf. KTB chief executive June Chepkemei has set a target of more than doubling Middle East arrivals, from 20,480 in the year to June to 50,000, built on what she calls a strategy of "air connectivity, targeted marketing and investment attraction." Connectivity is already there: Emirates flies Dubai to Nairobi three times daily, flydubai adds four weekly direct services, and Qatar Airways and Kenya Airways both work the corridor. Kenya's ambassador to the UAE, Kenneth Milimo Nganga, frames the push in explicitly financial terms: "The UAE is not only a source market for tourists, it is a strategic investment market for Kenya." A "One Diaspora, One Visitor" campaign and a Diaspora Open Day on 10 October are meant to convert Gulf-based Kenyans and their networks into both visitors and investors.

The target is more aspirational than the current base suggests. Of the 20,480 Middle East arrivals KTB is doubling from, Israel, Yemen and Iran together account for 48 per cent, a mix that reflects business travel, NGO movement and diaspora ties rather than the affluent leisure segment the marketing is aimed at. The UAE supplies 10 per cent of that base today, Saudi Arabia 7 per cent. Chepkemei's own framing, "connectivity has opened the door, our task now is to bring more travellers through it," is candid about how much work remains between capacity and demand. None of that makes the Gulf strategy wrong. Affluent Emirati and Saudi travellers spend well above the average international visitor, and a credible pipeline of Gulf capital into Kenyan hospitality and entertainment assets, which the embassy is explicitly courting, is worth having. But it is a different market, moving on a different timeline, from the one whose absence just cost the sector 600,000 domestic bed-nights.

The two efforts are not being run by the same department, and they are not being measured against each other. KTB's Gulf push has a named campaign, a named diaspora event, and an airline capacity table behind it. The domestic recovery effort amounts, so far, to a payments upgrade: the Tourist Tap mobile payment system, launched in April to make booking and paying for a Kenyan holiday easier, is a genuine improvement but addresses friction, not affordability. A traveller who has decided a coastal weekend is no longer in the household budget will not be moved by a faster checkout.

Rwanda's numbers, released in the same fortnight, describe an almost identical split. Domestic visits to national parks rose 8.1 per cent in 2025, to 59,270, and domestic park revenue grew 3.5 per cent to \$821,093, both genuine gains, but tiny against a sector that took in \$685 million overall on 1.49 million international arrivals, up 9 per cent. A Rwanda Development Board official pointed to "the perception that tourism is mainly for international or higher-income visitors, the overall cost of travel packages and competing household priorities" as the barrier keeping Rwandans out of their own parks. Cyprien Nshyimiyanana, a tour guide at Nyungwe National Park, put it more bluntly: "The issue cannot be looked at from just one angle. There is the issue of financial means, which we all know about, but there is also a lack of knowledge and understanding about certain things." Rwanda's response has been to build the discount into the price card rather than treat it as an afterthought: Akagera charges Rwf 15,000 for a Rwandan or other East African Community citizen against a far higher international rate, and Nyungwe sells a family annual pass, Rwf 205,000, that would be unthinkable at international gorilla-permit pricing. It is a small, structural acknowledgement that the local base needs a different price to stay in the market at all, not just a marketing campaign aimed elsewhere.

Zanzibar and mainland Tanzania sit on the international side of the same ledger: Zanzibar recorded 917,167 arrivals in 2025, up 24.5 per cent, and mainland Tanzania took in \$3.95 billion on 2.29 million visitors, with Ngorongoro's \$70.80 daily conservation fee plus a \$295 vehicle permit, and Serengeti and Nyerere both charging \$70 a day, pushing the cost of a premium safari well past what a regional family can contemplate. UN Tourism's new secretary-general, Shaikha Al Nowais, the first woman to hold the post, described the global backdrop in similar terms this month: "Demand for travel remained high throughout 2025, despite high inflation in tourism services and uncertainty from geopolitical tensions." Her point was about resilience at the top of the market. East Africa's own data this fortnight shows what that resilience is quietly costing at the bottom of it.

The timing has its own irony. Kenya opened UN Tourism Week in Nairobi on the day this piece was reported, running to 27 September, with Tourism Cabinet Secretary Rebecca Miano's ministry framing the week around

technology, data-driven destination management and "building resilient tourism systems through innovation." Miano herself struck a triumphant note in August, crediting four years of policy with having "radically revitalised Magical Kenya, delivering record-breaking tourism revenue and a surge in both international and domestic visitor arrivals." The surge in international arrivals is real and well documented. The surge in domestic arrivals, on the ministry's own numbers three weeks later, missed target by 600,000 nights. A week built around resilience is a reasonable moment to ask which half of the tourism economy that word is meant to describe.

None of this argues against courting Gulf capital or Gulf travellers; JKIA's climb to sixth in Africa by seat capacity this year, and the broader construction boom putting close to 80 per cent of Kenyan, Ethiopian and Tanzanian hotel pipeline rooms under active build, both depend on exactly that kind of international confidence. The argument is narrower: a marketing budget and a room-rate strategy built entirely around a high-spending inbound segment leaves a property more exposed, not less, to a domestic and regional base that has just shown it can shrink by 600,000 nights in a single year without international arrivals offsetting a single one of them, because the two segments do not fill the same rooms in the same season. Properties that kept a genuine local and East African Community rate card, the way Rwanda's parks have, are the ones with somewhere to turn when the cost of living squeezes the neighbours before it touches the tourists from further away.

For an owner setting next year's rate card, the practical question is not whether to chase the Gulf, almost every property with the room stock to do so should, but whether the domestic and EAC segment has been priced as a strategy or merely left as a residual. A genuine local rate, a genuine shoulder-season package, a genuine reason for a Nairobi or Kampala family to book a weekend rather than postpone it, is not charity. On this fortnight's numbers, it is the only line item that held the sector's occupancy together while the Gulf pipeline was still being built. The Gulf strategy and the domestic strategy are not competitors for the same marketing shilling. Kenya's own numbers this fortnight are the argument for running both at once, not for choosing between them.

BIG READ 3 OF 10 · 22 SEPTEMBER 2026

## From Sunday, Europe stops taking East Africa's lodges at their word

*On 27 September an EU consumer law makes "eco", "green" and offset-based "carbon neutral" unusable without proof. No East African lodge is under EU jurisdiction. Those that sell through European tour operators are about to discover that they do not need to be.*

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Sunday is World Tourism Day, and in eastern Uganda it closes three days of free national park entry that the government has pitched as an answer to the countries still advising against travel there. The more consequential event of 27 September will happen without a speech. From that day, a lodge that describes itself to a European holidaymaker as "eco-friendly", "green" or "responsible" will need something most have never been asked for: proof that a third party has checked.

The instrument is Directive (EU) 2024/825, known in Brussels as the Empowering Consumers for the Green Transition directive, or EmpCo. It was adopted in February 2024, member states were meant to write it into national law by 27 March this year, and it applies from Sunday. It creates no new regulator and no new form. It adds items to the annex of the EU's unfair commercial practices law, the short list of things a business may never do to a consumer, whatever the circumstances.

Four of those new items land squarely on hospitality. Displaying a sustainability label that is not based on a certification scheme or set by a public authority. Making a generic environmental claim without being able to show recognised excellent environmental performance. Claiming an environmental benefit for a whole business when it applies to only part of it. And claiming that a product has a neutral, reduced or positive effect on emissions on the strength of offsets bought outside the business's own value chain.

The word "annex" is doing a great deal of work. Practices on that list are banned outright; nobody has to prove that a particular guest was misled. The Finnish law firm Fondia, in a briefing for clients in May, spelt out a second consequence that should worry the region more than the first. "An environmental claim can take the form of text, imagery, graphics, or symbols, and it can also appear as a marketing name," its lawyers wrote. East Africa has a great many properties with "eco" in the name.

Stewart Moore, founder and chief executive of EarthCheck, one of the larger certification bodies, put the new position plainly to Tourism Update last week. "Broad terms such as 'green' or 'eco-friendly' carry more risk under the new rules unless they are backed by evidence," he said. "It raises the bar on both sides with greater transparency expected of the businesses making these claims and of the organisations verifying them."

The obvious objection from Nanyuki or Arusha is that none of this is East African law. That is true and nearly irrelevant. Sustainable Travel International's guidance for tourism businesses, published on 5 August, states that the rules reach companies that market to consumers in the EU regardless of where they are based. Relatively few lodges sell directly to a family in Bologna, though. Most are sold by a tour operator in Milan, Munich or Paris, whose brochure, website and sales script make claims about the camp. Those claims are the operator's legal problem. They are about to become the camp's commercial one.

Dominique Binns, a communications strategist at the impact-data company Baotree, made this argument in a piece for the Adventure Travel Trade Association back in March: African lodges face the consequences even without selling directly into Europe, because European operators featuring them in marketing need evidence for what they say. The operator carries the risk and will look for the evidence, and where it cannot find any, the easiest remedy is not a lawyer's letter to Laikipia. It is a product manager deleting a paragraph, or a property.

The largest of those operators had already moved. TUI Group states on its corporate site that it requires hotels to achieve certifications aligned with Global Sustainable Tourism Council criteria in its accommodation contracts,

and recognises more than 30 standards as meeting that bar, including Travelife, Green Key, Green Globe, EarthCheck and Biosphere. From Sunday, what was a procurement preference becomes a legal shield.

The markets in question are not marginal. Kenya's Tourism Research Institute counted 91,842 arrivals from Italy and 87,556 from Germany in 2024, according to figures published by The Star in January. Tanzania's International Visitors' Exit Survey, as reported this month, puts Italy at 11.8% of the country's visitors, France at 7.3%, Spain at 5.3% and Germany at 4.9%.

Samantha Smits, a sustainable tourism consultant, framed the upside for those who can document their case in terms any sales director will recognise. Verified information, she wrote for the Adventure Travel Trade Association on 14 September, "just saves your agents doing homework, which makes you a more attractive partner to choose and easier to do business with". The inverse is the risk. A supplier whose claims create homework is a supplier that is harder to choose.

If the answer is certification, the next question is which certificate, and here the region's position is untidy. Melissa Foley of Africa's Eden told Tourism Update that many operators remain "not at all ready", and described a landscape of nearly 40 certification schemes across the continent.

Kenya's homegrown option shows how quickly the rules underneath it have moved. Ecotourism Kenya's Standard for Tourist Accommodation, the basis of its Eco-rating, was first recognised by the GSTC in October 2016. It is not on the council's list of standards that kept that status on 1 January 2025. The reason matters more than the fact. In February 2023 the GSTC gave owners of recognised standards used for certification until 31 December 2024 to do one of two things: open an application for GSTC accreditation, or sign a formal arrangement handing their audits to certification bodies the GSTC has already accredited. Failing either, the council said, "means termination". Kenya's standard sits in the terminated table of the council's 31 December list, alongside several better-known international names.

The rule was written to end a confusion the council described bluntly. Recognition, it says, "only reviews the content and wording of the standard", not how it is audited. It counts more than 200 accommodation labels worldwide, many of which "do not comply with international norms on the definition of certification", and some of which are closer to "guided self-assessments". Two Indian Ocean competitors kept their place: the Seychelles Sustainable Tourism Label and Mauritius's Blue Oasis standard both appear on the council's list of standards still recognised from January 2025. The GSTC's own programme for online travel agencies and other distributors now includes only properties with accredited certification or a currently recognised standard.

None of this says Kenyan eco-rated lodges are not doing what they claim. Ecotourism Kenya's public list, which carries no date, names 79 rated facilities, 50 of them at gold, and the scheme may since have made the arrangements the GSTC asked for. But the directive asks the same question the GSTC now asks. It defines a certification scheme as third-party verification, open to any trader on transparent terms, with procedures for non-compliance and monitoring by a third party whose competence and independence rest on international, Union or national standards. The GSTC's revised manual for the bodies it accredits took effect on 5 March 2026 with a six-month transition, and requires them to comply with ISO/IEC 17065, the international standard for organisations that certify products and services. That transition ran out this month, days before EmpCo applies. Any owner relying on a label from Sunday should ask its scheme who audits it and on what basis their independence is established. An owner who has told a European operator that its rating is "GSTC-recognised" should check the council's current list before the operator does.

The offset rule is the cleanest break. "Carbon-neutral safari" has become a familiar line in itineraries, and it usually rests on credits bought to cover flights and game drives. Under EmpCo, a neutrality claim built on offsets outside the value chain is banned outright, whatever the quality of the credits. Sustainable Travel International's advice is to reframe offset spending as "an investment in climate action" beyond the business's own operations. It is a smaller claim, and one a lodge can keep making.

The paradox is that the directive favours exactly the kind of evidence East Africa's better operators already

possess. A camp that meters the share of its power that comes from solar, pays a published lease to a community conservancy per bed-night, or has removed single-use plastic and can show its supply records, has specific, measurable claims the law permits. What it cannot do is compress them into an adjective. The ban falls on "eco", not on the numbers underneath it. "If you can't measure it, you can't market it," Foley wrote on 10 September, in a guide for operators that is more useful than its slogan.

Kenya's largest European market is not in the EU at all. The UK sent 180,639 visitors to Kenya in 2024, per the Tourism Research Institute figures, and its rules are separate. They are not softer. Since 6 April 2025, under the Digital Markets, Competition and Consumers Act, the Competition and Markets Authority has been able to investigate consumer-law breaches itself and impose fines of up to 10% of global turnover without going to court.

Nor is there a single European referee. The Commission's separate Green Claims Directive, which would have set detailed rules on how claims are substantiated and verified before use, collapsed in June 2025 when the Commission said it would withdraw it rather than accept an amendment covering some 30 million micro-enterprises. The Commission was explicit that this "will not affect" EmpCo. But it means the new blacklist will be interpreted by national consumer authorities and courts, on national timetables. Fondia notes Sweden applies the rules from 1 January 2027 and Finland has a transition for certain provisions to March 2027. An operator selling in five EU markets cannot know which reading will bite first, and so it will apply the strictest one to every supplier.

Guy Bigwood, chief executive of the Global Destination Sustainability Movement, summed up the shift in May. "Sustainability is no longer just a story we tell," he said. "It is something we must prove."

What happens on Monday morning is not a raid. It is quieter and, for an unprepared property, more expensive. A European operator's content team works through its supplier pages and strips anything it cannot evidence. A property whose fact sheet says "eco-luxury" and nothing else becomes a property with a shorter description. The next time a programme is trimmed, the shorter description is easier to cut.

The work splits into what can be done this week and what cannot. This week, owners can read every surface where the property describes itself to a European reader: website, booking-engine blurb, OTA listing, Instagram biography, and above all the fact sheet held by each European tour operator and destination management company. Every adjective without a number behind it should be replaced with the number or deleted. Every "carbon neutral" line built on credits should go. A badge the property designed itself should come down.

What cannot be done this week is certification, which takes months. That is a decision worth making deliberately rather than under pressure from a contracting partner in the new year, and worth making on the basis of the directive's actual definition rather than a logo's familiarity.

East Africa's lodges have long argued that they do conservation rather than talk about it. From Sunday, Europe's consumer law takes them at their word only if someone else has checked it. The operators who can show their working have a sales advantage for the first time in years. Most of the ones who cannot will never see a fine. They will simply find, in next season's brochure, that they are harder to find.

BIG READ 4 OF 10 · 23 SEPTEMBER 2026

## AFCON 2027 will be priced, not filled

*CAF told Uganda this week that its rooms problem lies upcountry. America's World Cup, whose hotel results landed the same day, suggests the bigger risk for Nairobi, Kampala and Dar es Salaam is the opposite one: hotels that price out the guests they already have.*

The praise came first. At State House Entebbe on Tuesday, Bianca Wambui, the Confederation of African Football's country infrastructure manager, told President Yoweri Museveni what her inspectors had found at Uganda's competition stadiums and training grounds. "I would like to commend the efforts that have been put in so far, especially in terms of the stadiums and training grounds," she said. "The progress is commendable."

Then came the part that matters to anyone who sells a bed. The delegation, led by CAF's secretary general, Samson Adamu, had also found that accommodation outside the capital was a worry, and that the three co-hosts were moving too slowly on a single visa that would let fans, teams and officials cross freely between them, according to The EastAfrican and the Daily Monitor. Museveni did not dispute either point. "We hosted NAM here, which comprised 150 countries, and we were able to deal with them," he said, in remarks released by his deputy press secretary, Faruk Kirunda. "The Kampala area has the facilities, but now the challenge is upcountry, which we are now going to concentrate on." And then, for good measure: "I will unlock whatever needs to be unlocked."

The Africa Cup of Nations kicks off on 19 June 2027 across Uganda, Kenya and Tanzania, the first time the tournament has been split among three countries. Uganda's matches are due at Mandela National Stadium outside Kampala, the new Hoima City Stadium and the Akii-Bua Olympic Stadium in Lira. Nile Post reported on Tuesday that works at Hoima stood at about 95 per cent and at Lira at about 80 per cent, with the local organising committee promising all three by December. The instinct across the region, a reasonable one, is to count rooms and then build more of them.

The evidence published on the same Tuesday from the biggest World Cup ever staged suggests that counting rooms is the wrong exercise for most of East Africa's hotels, and a costly one for some.

Houston hosted seven World Cup matches between 14 June and 4 July this year. More than 480,000 spectators passed through its stadium and the Harris County Houston Sports Authority estimated half a million out-of-town visitors. By the end of June, according to CoStar data analysed by Bunmi Oyinloye of the consultancy HVS in a report published on 22 September, occupancy across Houston's hotels stood at 61.6 per cent, essentially unchanged on the year before. Average daily rate rose 5.8 per cent on the year, to \$131.67. The money was made on particular nights: rate was up roughly 52 per cent on the eve of the 17 June match and about 53 per cent on the night before the 4 July knockout game. Between those peaks, it drifted.

Houston's hoteliers had seen large events before and knew what one usually feels like. "When you have Super Bowl or Final Four, usually the day after they announce, you have no rooms to sell," said Emre Ozsut, regional director of sales at The Lancaster Hotel, in remarks reported by CoStar News in July. "In this, we were not even close to that."

Houston was not an outlier. In August, Thomas Hazinski, who leads the convention and sports facilities practice at HVS, compared performance in all eleven American host cities during match weeks with an estimate of what each market would have done without the tournament. Rate rose in every one of them, by between \$8.31 a night in Atlanta and \$62.27 in New York, and the eleven together earned an estimated \$680mn in extra rooms revenue. But occupancy fell below the no-tournament baseline in seven of the eleven. Seattle lost 6.3 percentage points. Hazinski's explanation was blunt: dynamic pricing "generated significant rate gains but also destroyed a meaningful share of the demand the market would otherwise have hosted." Ordinary business and leisure

travellers were priced out. Meeting planners, whose group rates had been contracted long before hotels switched to event pricing, simply moved their conferences to other weeks or other cities.

Didio Pequeno, who runs hospitality market analytics for CoStar in the north-east and Midwest of the United States, had forecast exactly this before the first whistle: "it's not really about demand, it's more so about markets being able to drive rate." Some owners found the rate less than they had been promised. John Fitzpatrick, chief executive of the Fitzpatrick Hotel Group in New York, told The City Reporter that revenue was up 15 per cent on the previous June. "The World Cup brought business to the city and it helped us, but I was expecting a lot more," he said. "It's not the big hype everybody was talking up."

The temptation is to treat this as an American curiosity, the story of a rich country with a vast hotel stock and fans who fly in for a match and fly out again. That would be a mistake, because two of Hazinski's findings travel to East Africa almost intact, and a third travels in a form that should worry the region's planners.

The first is that how much rate an event can extract depends on how full a market already is. New York, which would ordinarily have run at 89.4 per cent occupancy during those weeks, captured the largest rate gain in the study, \$62.3 a night. Houston, with the lowest baseline at 61.2 per cent, captured one of the smallest, \$17.1. A market that is nearly full in a normal week has nowhere to put extra demand except into price. A market with slack absorbs it and gains little.

The second is about location. Atlanta, whose stadium sits beside the city's main convention centre, recorded the smallest rate gain of all eleven, because tournament crowds displaced the conference business that would normally have filled those hotels. Seattle and Philadelphia, with similar geography, also underperformed. Kansas City, whose venue lies well away from its convention cluster, did far better than its ordinary occupancy predicted.

The third concerns who travels. Hazinski noted that teams from countries with smaller populations and less disposable income, naming Senegal, Côte d'Ivoire and Cabo Verde among them, generated comparatively few room nights, while France, England, Spain, Brazil and Argentina brought crowds. A World Cup in the United States and a Nations Cup in East Africa are different animals: most AFCON supporters can be expected to come from within Africa, many of them overland, and the distances are shorter. But the constraint is the same one. Supporters travel when they can afford to and when the border lets them, which is why Adamu spent part of Tuesday pressing Uganda's President on a visa that does not yet exist.

Put those findings against East Africa's calendar and AFCON 2027 turns out to be two different tournaments.

In Nairobi, Kampala and Dar es Salaam, the question is not whether there will be enough rooms. Museveni himself says Kampala has the facilities. The question is what hotels do with rate in the four weeks from 19 June, which is also the moment East Africa's safari high season opens and the city hotels start filling with guests on their way to the Mara, the Serengeti and Bwindi. Those guests, and the conference groups who use the same properties, are the ones who book early. Tournament visitors, on the American evidence, book late. Rosanna Maietta, chief executive of the American Hotel and Lodging Association, said in July that demand had picked up "consistent with a recent trend toward shorter booking windows for events of this caliber", because "many travelers finalized plans and secured tickets closer to the start of the games."

That is the trap. A Nairobi or Kampala hotel that holds rooms back for AFCON, or quotes tournament rates across the whole month, will be turning away its most reliable business in the autumn of 2026 in order to wait for customers who may not decide until the spring of 2027, and who may not come in the numbers the planners hope. Hazinski's demand destruction does not require a hotel to overprice on match night. It only requires a planner or a tour operator to see a high rate in the window and take the group, or the safari pre-night, somewhere else. East Africa has competitors for that business in a way Houston did not, and the buyers are already choosing: European operators were discussing AFCON itineraries with Ugandan sellers at IFTM Top Resa in Paris on 16 September.

Hoima is the other tournament, and it is Houston's problem turned inside out. There, the shortage is real. A CAF inspection report cited by the Daily Monitor, and repeated this week by the Kawowo columnist John Philip Mugabi, called for at least five five-star hotels of at least 50 rooms each for teams and officials. The response has been to build: seven hotels in Hoima and three in Masindi have been selected for official guests, one group is reportedly expanding its combined capacity from 102 rooms to 259, and government has set aside Shs101.1bn in cheap credit through the Uganda Development Bank for hotel upgrades in the two towns.

The HVS finding about baseline occupancy applies here too, in reverse. Rooms built for a four-week peak earn their keep in the forty-eight weeks that follow, and a market with a thin ordinary baseline is exactly the kind that captures little from an event and then carries the capacity afterwards. Mugabi, writing on Tuesday, framed the dilemma in a single question, "Where will everybody sleep?", before arguing for a modular accommodation village with a planned second life. "Build for the tournament, but design for the aftermath," he wrote. He also points to what makes Hoima unusual: an oil and gas economy that may supply the year-round demand a football tournament cannot. That is the right test for every new room going up in Bunyoro. The case has to close on the traffic of 2028, with AFCON treated as a bonus rather than the business plan.

For owners, the practical conclusions are unglamorous, which is usually a sign they are right. Look up your own occupancy for the last two Junes and Julys before deciding anything; the American evidence says that number, not the size of the crowd, determines how much rate you can take. Honour and protect the contracted safari, conference and group business in those weeks first, and price the match nights, and the nights before them, rather than the whole month. Put an event clause in 2027 group contracts now, so that a planner is not ambushed by a rate change and does not move the meeting to Kigali. Bush and beach properties should treat the tournament as a source of add-on nights for travelling supporters rather than a reason to reprice. And anyone building upcountry should underwrite the project on the year after the tournament, not the month of it.

None of the American numbers can be transplanted wholesale, and nobody yet knows how many supporters will cross East Africa's borders next June, least of all while the single visa remains a promise. But the lesson Houston's hoteliers learned the expensive way is available free of charge. A tournament does not fill a city. It tells the city's hotels what they can charge, and it punishes those that forget who was already sleeping there.

BIG READ 5 OF 10 · 23 SEPTEMBER 2026

## East Africa's hotels no longer set the price of their own staff

*A parliamentary committee in Mombasa spent this year clearing paperwork so more Kenyan hospitality workers can join cruise ships. A tourism week in Eldoret is training the ones who stay. The wage that decides which of those two things happens is being set somewhere else entirely.*

The tents went up on the grounds of the University of Eldoret on Monday. Kenya's 2026 UN Tourism Week runs there from 21 to 27 September under the theme "Digital Agenda and Artificial Intelligence to Redesign Tourism", and the guest list reads like an inventory of everyone the sector needs to keep: tour operators, hoteliers, guides, community tourism enterprises, county officials, technology firms. Julius Bitok, principal secretary for tourism, promised a week of participation rather than spectacle. "We have lined up many interesting activities to not only see but to actively participate in," he said.

The theme is not Kenya's invention. It belongs to UN Tourism, whose General Assembly in Riyadh last November designated El Salvador as official host of World Tourism Day 2026 and set that phrase as the year's global frame. Kenya took the frame and built a national week around it, in a North Rift town with neither a beach nor a headline park, which is itself an argument about where Kenyan tourism should grow next.

It is a good week and a reasonable bet. It also rests on the assumption that the scarce thing in East African hospitality is knowledge. But the binding constraint in a Nairobi or Arusha or Kigali hotel this quarter is not knowing what a revenue management system does. It is finding someone still at the property in eighteen months to operate it. And the price of that person is no longer set in East Africa.

Consider what a different arm of the Kenyan state was doing while the tourism ministry planned Eldoret.

On 29 April, the National Assembly's Committee on Diaspora Affairs and Migrant Workers met executives of Mediterranean Shipping Company at the Kenya Ports Authority offices in Mombasa. The subject was how to get more Kenyans onto cruise ships. MSC's managing director in Kenya, Captain Fiorenzo Castellano, told the committee the company had established a dedicated ten-member team in the country working on recruitment alone, and had run outreach campaigns in Malindi, Diani, Voi and Nairobi. The committee's own business was the bottleneck: delays in issuing the Seafarers Identification Document, without which a Kenyan cannot join a foreign crew.

"We have had extensive engagements on the issue of SID, including with the relevant cabinet secretaries," the committee's chairperson, Lydia Haika, said. "It is a matter we are keen to resolve."

Read that list of towns again. Malindi, Diani, Voi are the labour catchment for the coastal resort belt, the places a Diani general manager recruits from, and a shipping line has put a permanent ten-person team into the country to recruit from them. Nobody is doing anything improper. MSC is hiring lawfully, the committee is serving constituents who want the jobs, and the remittances are real. But the effect is that the Kenyan state is lowering the cost of exporting the very workers another part of the same state is spending a week in Eldoret trying to upskill.

The second bid comes from the north. At Arabian Travel Market in Dubai this month, the conversation among Gulf operators was about hiring, and it was notably not about pay. Pedro Lacerda of TASC Outsourcing framed it as logistics rather than budget. "Businesses may know the number of people they need, but sourcing, screening, onboarding and deploying that workforce within the required timeframe can determine how effectively they respond to business demand," he said. Catalina Susan, general manager of the Marriott Hotel Al Forsan in Abu Dhabi, put the specification plainly: "The challenge is less about finding experience and more about finding the right skills, attitude and adaptability."

Greg Kocsis, hotel manager at the Taj Exotica on The Palm, described what luxury properties are actually

shopping for. "Genuine warmth, empathy, attention to detail and the ability to anticipate a guest's needs are just as important as experience," he said.

That is a precise description of the East African front-of-house profile, the one thing the region has never had to import. It is also a trait a Gulf employer can buy without paying for the years that produced it.

Notice what none of those three executives said. Not one of them described the contest as a bidding war, because where the binding constraint is people rather than money the employer who wins is the one offering a trajectory rather than a rate. East African operators are running the opposite calculation. They are anchoring their wage structures to a number fixed by a government gazette, and in both of the region's largest markets that number has just moved.

Kenya's instrument is Legal Notice No. 95, the Regulation of Wages (General) (Amendment) Order 2026, made under the Labour Institutions Act by the Cabinet Secretary for Labour and Social Protection, Alfred Mutua, on 7 May and published in Kenya Gazette Supplement No. 128 on 29 May, deemed to have come into operation on 1 May. Its schedule repays reading in the town where the tents went up this week, because the order's highest wage column covers "Nairobi, Mombasa, Kisumu, Nakuru and Eldoret Cities". The second occupational band in that column, which files waiters and cooks alongside miners, stone cutters and loggers, sets a basic minimum of Ksh 19,491.33 a month, exclusive of housing allowance. A receptionist sits five bands higher at Ksh 27,796.51 and a cashier at Ksh 40,724.23. Those are the floors under the people being taught to redesign tourism at the University of Eldoret this week.

Tanzania went further and gave hospitality a category of its own. Government Notice No. 605A of 2025, published on 13 October 2025 and in force from 1 January 2026, sets a monthly minimum of TZS 375,000 in five and four star hotels, TZS 225,000 in three star hotels, TZS 195,000 in one and two star properties, guest houses, bars and restaurants, and TZS 320,000 for tour guides, against a general catch-all private sector rate of TZS 175,000. Tanzania has decided that hospitality should pay more than twice the economy's baseline.

None of that is the problem. A rising statutory floor in a sector with this much guest-facing skill is defensible policy. The problem is what an operator does with it. Too many East African wage structures are built upwards from the gazette, as though the legal minimum were a market signal. It is not. It is a floor, and the clearing price for a trained, English-speaking, systems-literate food and beverage supervisor is being quoted by a crewing office in Mombasa and a human resources department in Abu Dhabi. Budgeting to the gazette is a forecast that your best people will accept less than they are being offered elsewhere.

The training system cannot close the gap on the timescale the rooms require. Abdou Belgat, president of the international hospitality education body AMFORHT, argues the fix is structural rather than a matter of volume. "Training differently means rethinking curricula to ground them in African realities, while aligning with international standards," he said.

East Africa's own institutions are moving, slowly and in the right direction. Kenya Utalii College began admitting through the national placement service in January, a first, with its principal, Mark Ogendi, calling the change a game-changer as the college expands into Kisumu, Kilifi and Narok. In Uganda, enrolment at the Uganda Hotel and Tourism Training Institute has tripled in recent years, which sounds like an answer until it is sized against the hole.

UHTTI is the country's only government hospitality school. When its principal, Richard Kawere, last set the numbers out publicly, it held roughly 1,000 students against more than 2,500 applications and was aiming at 1,500. "It is only when we increase the capacity, infrastructure that we will be able to uptake some of these students who apply and they are not taken because of limited capacity," he said. Its graduating class that year was 459. Set that against the International Organisation for Migration survey cited in June, which put Uganda's need at roughly 15,000 additional workers, and the arithmetic is not close: the national pipeline at full stretch fills that gap in something over a decade, and many of those graduates leave for the Middle East soon after qualifying.

Which brings the argument to the layer where East African properties are actually losing people, and it is not the one most owners watch.

A recruitment consultancy case study published on 14 September describes a Nairobi group that grew from two properties to eight in under three years. It had done what fast-growing groups do: promoted its strongest front desk agents, housekeeping leads and guest relations officers into supervisory roles. Within six months, three properties showed falling guest satisfaction and turnover close to double the group average. The exit interviews did not point at pay or workload. They pointed at management. One departing employee's verdict, as the study records it, was that "my supervisor is great at the job herself. She just doesn't know how to manage people who aren't like her."

That is an anonymised account from a firm that sells training, and should be read with that in mind. But it describes a failure mode any East African operator will recognise, and it is the one piece of this problem that is cheap to fix. The group put 35 supervisors through cohort training in feedback, conflict resolution, multilingual communication and motivating without formal authority, and reported turnover at the weak properties converging with the rest.

The stakes are not marginal. The World Travel and Tourism Council's Kenya factsheet, released on 15 June, put travel and tourism at 9.3 per cent of Kenyan GDP in 2025 and 1.8 million jobs, or 8.3 per cent of national employment. Its workforce study, presented in Rome last October, forecast a global shortfall of 43 million travel and tourism jobs by 2035, hospitality alone running some 8.6 million short.

The supply side is not waiting. W Hospitality Group's March report counted 6,190 pipeline rooms in Kenya, 79.5 per cent of them already under construction. Concrete opens on a schedule. People do not.

There is a version of this story in which the outflow is benign. Remittances are substantial, and a cruise contract or a Gulf posting often returns a better-trained person three years later. But Tanzania has also been tightening enforcement on foreign work permits, with the deputy labour minister, Evaline Munisi, warning in June that the government "will not hesitate to take strong legal action" against employers who break the rules. That closes the expatriate valve at the top of the org chart just as the local line beneath it thins, which makes the domestic pipeline more load-bearing, not less.

Three things are worth doing before the year closes, and none requires a policy change.

Budget labour at the clearing price rather than the gazette. If a crewing agent in Mombasa or a recruiter in Dubai is quoting your head chef, that quote is your market, and a wage structure indexed to Legal Notice 95 will be arbitrated.

Cost the replacement, not the salary. The expensive number is not the increment that would have retained a trained supervisor. It is the recruitment, the training cycle and the months of degraded guest scores in between, and almost nobody in the region books that figure anywhere a general manager can see it.

Fund the supervisor layer first. It is where promotions outrun preparation, where exit interviews keep pointing, and the cheapest retention instrument available to an owner who cannot outbid a cruise line.

Eldoret is the right instinct. A sector that wants to sell something other than beach and wildlife has to build capability in places that have neither. But capability is carried by people, and this year the people are being bid for by employers who did not pay to train them and will not be at the University of Eldoret this week.

BIG READ 6 OF 10 · 24 SEPTEMBER 2026

## Hilton promised owners their margin back. In East Africa, the state decides whether it arrives.

*On Wednesday in New York, Hilton's chief executive put a number on what the brands now owe their owners: 75 to 100 basis points, taken out of labour, energy and insurance. Across Africa more owners than ever are signing franchise deals that leave those three lines on their own profit and loss account, and in East Africa two of them move by gazette notice.*

Christopher Nassetta has been in the hotel business for more than four decades, and on Wednesday afternoon in New York he told a room full of travel executives that he had never seen a stretch quite like the one his owners have just lived through.

"It's really abnormal in my experience of 40-plus years of doing this, where you would have essentially, other than a sugar high, a really difficult 10 years," Hilton's president and chief executive said on the Skift Global Forum stage on 23 September, running through the sequence: the long convalescence after 2008, growth he called "really anemic" in 2017 and 2018, a pandemic that removed more than 90 per cent of revenue, a stimulus-fuelled rebound, then several years of thin growth against stubborn inflation.

What made the remarks worth reading from Nairobi was not the diagnosis. It was the number attached to the cure. Hilton's answer to a decade of squeezed owner returns is a cost review it calls Project RISE, and on the company's second-quarter earnings call in July Nassetta put its value to owners at "somewhere between 75 and 100 basis points in margin." The programme, launched in 2025 and rolled out through this year, sits alongside a cut in loyalty fees and a scheme that discounts fees for hotels delivering strong guest scores. The three cost lines it goes after are labour, energy and insurance. The next phase, Nassetta said in New York, leans on artificial intelligence to take out distribution and operating cost.

Read that as a shift in what a global brand is selling. For thirty years the pitch to an owner in an emerging market was demand: sign with us and the rooms fill. The pitch now increasingly includes the expense side of the profit and loss account, because that is where owners have been losing. And it is arriving in East Africa at precisely the moment the region's owners are signing the kind of contract that makes the expense side entirely theirs.

Hilton signed 29 deals across 15 African countries in 2025 and says it remains on track to open more than 100 hotels on the continent, over half of them in sub-Saharan Africa, taking its African portfolio past 180 properties trading and in development. "Sub-Saharan Africa remains a strategically important growth region for Hilton," Carlos Khneisser, the group's chief development officer for the Middle East and Africa, said when the signings were announced in the spring. East Africa's share of that includes the AVA Hotel Nairobi, a 91-room property in Lavington that brings the Tapestry Collection to Kenya for the first time, and Canopy by Hilton Zanzibar The Burj.

The structural change underneath those signings is the one that deserves an owner's attention. For years the African pipeline ran on management agreements, where the chain takes over the operation: Trevor Ward of W Hospitality Group has put it at roughly 81 per cent of the continent's 2024 pipeline. That is now moving. The firm's January 2026 count, reported in March, found 146 franchise agreements in the African development pipeline, 35 per cent more than a year earlier and 22 per cent of the total, up from 18.7 per cent.

Ward's own description of the difference is the whole argument in a sentence. Under a franchise, he said, "the chain provides the brand and supports revenue generation, but day-to-day operations remain the owner's responsibility."

So when a brand promises 75 to 100 basis points of margin, an owner on a franchise deal is not being offered a share of someone else's operating improvement. They are being told that their own costs will fall because of

programmes the brand runs. That claim is testable, line by line, and in East Africa it does not survive contact with two of the three lines.

Start with energy. Kenya's September pass-through charge was set by gazette notice on 18 September at Ksh4.16 for every kilowatt hour consumed, made up of a Ksh3.00 fuel energy cost charge covering thermal generation at Kipevu III and Rabai, roughly Ksh1.14 of foreign exchange fluctuation adjustment tied to some Ksh1.32 billion of currency cost, and a fraction of a cent for water resource management. A hotel in Westlands pays that because the regulator published it, and it pays the forex component because the shilling moved. There is no global procurement contract, no group energy desk and no AI scheduling tool that negotiates a gazette notice. The lever the brand can genuinely pull, consumption, is the one Kenyan operators have already been pulling for three years, and the route off the grid narrowed this month when the same regulator halved the credit paid for power that a property exports back into it.

Labour is worse, because it is set by law and it has just moved. Tanzania's Labour Institutions (Minimum Wage for Private Sector) Order, published as Government Notice 605A in October last year, took effect on 1 January and rewrote the floor for accommodation. Five and four-star hotels: TZS 375,000 a month. Three-star: TZS 225,000. One and two-star hotels, guesthouses, lodgings, bars and restaurants: TZS 195,000. Tour guides: TZS 320,000. A hotel owner in Dar es Salaam or on the Zanzibar coast did not negotiate those numbers with a brand, a union or a supplier. They were gazetted.

The productivity half of the labour promise is real, and it is the part East African owners should look at most sceptically, because of where it is measured. HotelData's half-year report, published on 17 September, found United States full-service hotels cut hours per occupied room by 3.1 per cent year on year and select-service hotels by 3.5 per cent, with room attendants at select-service properties taking 22.82 minutes a room against 24.01 a year earlier, while hourly housekeeping wages rose between 2.9 and 3.3 per cent. That is a genuine gain and a well-instrumented one. It was also produced inside American select-service labour models, on stock that looks nothing like a Zanzibar beach resort with a full kitchen brigade, or a Mara camp that houses and feeds its staff on site because there is nowhere else for them to live.

Insurance is the line where global scale most plausibly does travel, since placement is an international market and a brand-wide programme can price risk across hundreds of properties. It is also the hardest line to verify from outside a signed agreement, and no owner should accept it as a rounding assumption. The right response to a margin claim built partly on insurance is to ask for the placement: which carrier, which programme, which currency, and what an East African property's loss history actually does to its share of it.

The revenue half of the brands' case has held up better, and it is getting more concentrated. Anthony Capuano, Marriott's chief executive, told a Bank of America conference on 9 September that "the biggest impact you'll see on our industry is the distribution landscape," and described feeding Google and OpenAI large volumes of portfolio content so that Marriott hotels "show up in a really both authentic but prominent way." Nassetta made the same argument from Hilton's side in New York, saying the company intends to be present in every channel a customer books through, with the scale to stay in the relationship: a quarter of United States quality supply and a loyalty programme he put at 300 million members.

For a city hotel in Nairobi or Kigali carrying a global flag, that is worth real money and should not be discounted. A Hilton Honors member choosing Lavington over an unbranded competitor is exactly the mechanism owners pay for. But it decays fast as you move away from the transient business traveller. The demand that fills a Zanzibar resort in the European winter, or a Serengeti camp in the migration, is contracted months in advance through French, German, Italian and British tour operators, and no loyalty database substitutes for a place in a long-haul programme. An owner signing a franchise this quarter is buying strong visibility in the channels that matter least to their peak season.

There is also a cost in that promise that nobody in New York would allocate. On the same day Nassetta spoke, Elena Avila, who runs travel distribution at Amadeus, and Steve Singh of Spotnana were on another Skift stage

discussing who pays for the compute, search load, security and data governance that agentic AI booking requires. Neither would say. Avila's warning was that the revenue is not automatic: "I think we shouldn't just be complacent and think that revenue will simply come." An unallocated cost in a franchised system has a default home, and it is the owner's profit and loss account, arriving as a line on a monthly fee statement.

Which is why the most interesting counter-structure in African hospitality right now is not a brand at all. In June last year Aleph Hospitality took over management of 26 Onomo hotels across 14 African countries, a deal its executive director Neil George described as "the largest transition from management to franchising ever in the continent." George was pointed about what Aleph sells against: "It is not remote-controlled management, which we have an allergy for." The firm now operates more than 50 hotels in 23 countries with another 30 in development, is opening offices in Nairobi, Cape Town, Casablanca and Abidjan, and targets 100 hotels by the end of 2029. Its founder, Bani Haddad, reads the growth as a verdict on structure: "Our continued growth reflects the strength of our business model and the increasing demand from hotel owners for an experienced independent operator in the region." Aleph is also the operator running Kenya's first Tapestry Collection hotel under the Hilton flag.

That is the shape of the choice now available to an East African owner, and it is better than the one available five years ago. Licence the brand for what it demonstrably delivers, distribution and recognition, and buy operating capability from someone whose own margin depends on East African costs rather than American ones.

Three things belong in the negotiation before any margin promise is paid for. Ask the brand to name, for your country, the counterparty behind each cost programme it is claiming: the supplier, the contract, the currency. Ask for a cap and a stated basis for technology and distribution surcharges, because the industry's tech bill is rising and its own executives will not say who carries it. And ask for the brand's delivered share of room nights at comparable properties in your market rather than the global figure, because the global figure is mostly America.

The offer on the table has genuinely improved. A basis point, though, is only a basis point where the brand can reach the cost. In Nairobi the price of a kilowatt hour was decided by a notice dated 18 September. In Dar es Salaam the wage floor was decided by a government notice last October. Neither was negotiable, neither appears in a franchise agreement, and between them they move more of an East African hotel's margin than any programme designed in Virginia.

BIG READ 7 OF 10 · 25 SEPTEMBER 2026

## East Africa knows how wet this season will be. It does not know what its cover is worth.

*Kenya's state reinsurer went shopping for a catastrophe model last Thursday, days before the start of a short rains season that forecasters have already compared to 1997 and 2023. For lodges and coastal hotels, the exposure that matters this quarter is not the water. It is the wording.*

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Last Thursday, with October a week away, Kenya Reinsurance Corporation invited bids from modelling firms to map its exposure to floods and earthquakes across East Africa, and to work out how that exposure might translate into losses. The state-owned reinsurer sits behind a large share of the property cover written in Kenya, Uganda and Tanzania. It was, in effect, publishing a notice that it does not yet know the answer.

The timing is the story. Five weeks earlier, on 18 August, the Climate Prediction and Applications Centre run by IGAD, the regional bloc that groups Kenya, Uganda, Tanzania and six neighbours, had already told the region what was coming. Its October to December outlook put the probability of enhanced rainfall at 90 per cent over southern Ethiopia, central and southern Somalia and north-eastern Kenya, with seasonal totals likely to exceed 400mm across central Kenya, the Lake Victoria basin, Burundi, western Rwanda and western Tanzania. Onset would be early to normal across most of Tanzania and central-eastern Kenya. The drivers were a strengthening El Niño and a positive Indian Ocean Dipole. The forum named its analogue years: 1997 and 2023.

Anyone who has run a camp in the Mara or a beach property south of Mombasa knows what those two years mean. The Kenya Meteorological Service followed with an outlook putting above-average rainfall over roughly 80 per cent of the country. In Zanzibar, where the Vuli rains land on an island whose entire high season begins in December, the Disaster Management Commission identified 75 vulnerable administrative areas and 105 buildings in poor condition in Stone Town, 27 of them needing urgent attention, with November expected to be the heaviest month. President Hussein Mwinyi ordered drains cleared and told residents in the worst zones to move before the rain intensified.

So the meteorology is not the uncertainty. It has been published, in public, for more than a month, by the region's own institutions. The uncertainty is contractual, and it sits inside policy documents that most East African hospitality operators have not opened since they renewed.

Consider what actually happened the last time this region got the season it is now being promised. On 4 May 2024, the Mara Managers Association issued a statement describing camps and lodges near the Mara, Talek and Sand rivers as partially or fully submerged. Three bridges were impassable: Talek gate, Mara Simba and Mara Rianta. The Mara bridge itself was destroyed. "All tourists were safely evacuated from camps and lodges where needed," Samwel Leposo, the county's chief officer for tourism, said at the time, and that was true and was the only comfortable sentence in the document. The Standard reported that twelve tented camps and lodges had been destroyed.

Read that list again as an insurance problem rather than a weather one. A submerged tent is physical damage at the insured premises, which is the simplest claim a property policy handles. A destroyed public bridge fourteen kilometres away is not. It closes the camp just as completely, it cancels the same bookings, it strands the same guests, and under the standard wording of most property and business interruption policies sold in the region it triggers nothing at all, because nothing at the insured location was damaged. Business interruption cover in its ordinary form responds to the consequences of an insured physical loss at the premises. Loss of access caused by damage to someone else's infrastructure requires a specific extension, usually capped, usually with a distance limit, and usually not bought.

That is the first gap. The second is slower and more corrosive.

Kenya's Insurance Regulatory Authority counted more than 850 flood claims worth KSh3.145 billion by the end of April 2024, a figure that rose 62 per cent to around KSh5 billion by June. Nairobi accounted for 673 of those claims and KSh2.7 billion of the value. By the end of April, the amount actually settled stood at KSh147.3 million. That is under five per cent of what had been claimed by then. Every camp manager who has ever been told that cover is in place should sit with that ratio for a moment. Cover existing and cover paying are separate events, and in the 2024 season they were separated by a great deal of time.

What fills that gap is argument, and the Kenyan market's record on contested large claims is not reassuring. On 15 September, Business Daily set out the case of Mombasa Cement against Kenindia Insurance over a blending silo that collapsed on 1 August 2011. The insurer declined. The dispute ran for fifteen years. The claim, lodged at KSh1.64 billion, was eventually settled by the courts at KSh4.2 billion. The company won. It also spent fifteen years winning, which no seasonal lodge with a bank facility and a December payroll can do.

Individual disputes like that one stall for years. The national bill does not wait for them to resolve. The scale of what is at stake is no longer in dispute. The National Treasury's Disaster Risk Financing Strategy 2026 to 2030 puts total damages and losses from the October to December 2023 and March to May 2024 floods at KSh187.82 billion. Kenya's own 2026 flood season, which ran from March into April, killed 112 people across thirty counties and displaced almost 35,000 before this year's short rains had even been forecast. The insurers have felt it directly. "We had floods last year and into this year in the first quarter. Last year, we paid over KSh200 million worth of flood-related claims," Japheth Ogalloh, managing director of Old Mutual, said in May. "In general, risks related to climate change are becoming more frequent and severe."

The industry's response so far has been to talk about structure rather than price. Kenya Re has publicly argued for a national flood pool bringing together the reinsurer, direct insurers, government and capital markets, with the state carrying the extreme tail. That is a sensible idea and it will not exist this quarter. Neither will the catastrophe model the corporation went to tender for last week. Procurement, data assembly and calibration for a multi-country flood and seismic model is a matter of many months. The season starts next week.

Which means the 2026 short rains will be underwritten the way the last ones were: on judgement, memory and treaty capacity set somewhere else. For a lodge owner that has one practical consequence. The pricing of your cover this year does not reflect the forecast, because nobody in the chain has a model that ingests it. That cuts both ways. It means you are unlikely to be surcharged for a season the forum has already called. It also means the insurer has not stress-tested what happens if every camp on three rivers claims in the same fortnight, and aggregate catastrophe limits are where that arithmetic shows up.

Jared Kangwana, managing partner in Kenya at Clyde & Co, put the point more precisely than any broker's circular this month, writing with his colleagues Esther Boyani and Lucy Mwaniki on 16 September. "The best time to discover an ambiguity in a flood definition, an inadequate catastrophe limit or a gap between insurance and reinsurance coverage is before the rains arrive," they wrote. The three ambiguities they name are exactly the three that decide whether an East African property is insured or merely holding a document. Does the policy's flood definition cover rising surface water as well as the overflow of a watercourse? Is the catastrophe limit set per location or aggregated across every camp in the group, and if aggregated, at what number? And does the local insurer's own reinsurance treaty stretch far enough that a regional event does not turn into a negotiation about what it can afford?

There is a longer-run version of this that owners should see coming. Climate exposure has already begun to function as a capital gate in African hospitality, not merely a cost line. "The IFC, for example, will not lend unless a project is green-compliant," Trevor Ward, managing director of W Hospitality Group, noted in April. "Insurance companies will assess the risks involved in complying or not complying and may not provide cover." Judy Kepher-Gona, founder of the Sustainable Travel and Tourism Agenda, framed the same shift in terms of who gets to own the assets. "Climate is increasingly becoming a barrier to local ownership," she said, pointing to

certification, carbon assessment and de-risking requirements that reward developers with balance sheets deep enough to absorb them. A season that produces contested claims across the Mara, the Lake basin and the coast will accelerate that sorting, because the properties that cannot demonstrate resilience are the ones that will be quoted out of cover first.

None of this argues for pessimism about the quarter. Coastal bookings held through the early September rains, and the region has traded through worse. It argues for a fortnight of unglamorous work, and the list is short enough to finish before the ground softens:

Photograph and date the condition of every structure, bund, culvert and access road now, because the pre-loss baseline is what a loss adjuster will ask for and what nobody ever has.

Read the business interruption section and find out whether denial of access, damage to someone else's infrastructure that cuts off your own guests, is actually in it.

Ask the broker, in writing, for the aggregate catastrophe limit across the whole portfolio, not the per-property sum insured, so a shared-river event does not exhaust cover camp by camp.

Ask what the flood definition says: whether it covers rising surface water as well as the overflow of a watercourse, in those exact words.

Kenya Re will get its model. The forecast that model would have validated is already public, and it has been public since August. The gap between those two facts is where this season's losses will be argued, and the operators who close it will do so in the next two weeks, with a policy document and a pen, not after the water arrives.

BIG READ 8 OF 10 · 26 SEPTEMBER 2026

## The AI agent will book your room. It will still buy it from an OTA.

*Expedia announced this week that it was joining Meta's new travel agent. Its shares closed down almost 8 per cent the next day, and Booking, Airbnb and TripAdvisor fell with it. The market understood something East African operators should: in the agent era the commission does not disappear, only the shopfront does.*

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Expedia spent this week doing what a company does when it has decided which side of a technological shift it wants to be on. It announced that travellers would soon be able to plan and book hotels and trips directly inside Meta's new personal agent, Muse, without visiting an Expedia site at all. Expedia would remain the merchant of record. The transaction would stay its transaction. Only the window the traveller looks through would change.

The market read the announcement and sold. Expedia closed down almost 8 per cent on Wednesday. Booking Holdings fell 5 per cent to a session low of \$155.37, within touching distance of its 52-week low, and is down roughly 29 per cent on the year. Airbnb fell 6 per cent. Meta rose. Measured from Muse's launch in the first week of September to Wednesday's close, the damage is heavier still: Expedia down 13.1 per cent, TripAdvisor 13.8 per cent, Airbnb 17.8 per cent, Booking 19.3 per cent, against Meta up 20.6 per cent.

For a lodge owner in Laikipia or on Zanzibar's east coast, the temptation is to read that as good news. The middleman is finally being disciplined. The commission is under threat at last. That reading is almost exactly backwards, and the reason is visible in the plumbing rather than the share price.

Look at what Muse actually does with a trip. For flights it runs on Duffel, the London booking infrastructure company, which since 9 September has given the agent live, bookable inventory across more than 500 airlines. That is a genuine pipe, direct to the carrier. "Travel is the ultimate stress test for an AI agent," said Steve Domin, Duffel's co-founder and chief executive. "It's dynamic, complex and deeply personal and when something goes wrong, the consequences are real."

For hotels there was no pipe at all. As Adriana Lee, Skift's travel technology reporter, established when she examined the launch, Muse shopped rooms by opening a browser and going to consumer websites, Expedia and Hotels.com among them, with no defined commercial relationship with the supplier and the agent rather than any travel integration deciding where the search went. Now Expedia is formalising that path. The arrangement makes official what the robot was already doing informally: rooms in East Africa are sold through an aggregator, and the aggregator keeps the customer.

So the asymmetry holds. The flight to Jomo Kenyatta gets cheaper to distribute. The room does not. What the agent removes is not the intermediary but the property's last sightline to the guest.

Alejandro Berdonces Corroto put the underlying problem plainly in an analysis for Hospitality Net in August, updated on 7 September as the Muse details firmed up: "no settled commission structure exists for when an AI agent executes the booking on the traveller's behalf." His reading of where that vacuum leads is the argument East African operators should be having this month and mostly are not. "OTAs are positioned to replay inside AI assistants the same move they made in search: absent specific regulation, independent hotels will spend years paying, again."

That is the mechanism, and this week supplied the proof. An agent that books through Expedia is not disintermediating Expedia. It is doing Expedia's customer acquisition at machine speed and at no cost, and the commission on the resulting booking is the commission that was always there. The only variable that has moved is the cost of being shopped.

Berdonces Corroto's sharpest line goes to what commission was ever for. It "was never really a fixed percentage so much as the price paid for not controlling the relationship with the end guest." By that definition an agentic booking is the most expensive kind a property can take. The lodge never sees the traveller, never sees the query, never learns which twelve properties it lost to, and pays the full rate for the privilege.

There is a second cost, less discussed and arriving sooner. Lee's reporting flags that Meta's surfaces reach 3.6 billion daily users and that an agent operating at that scale could sharply inflate look-to-book ratios and raise infrastructure costs for suppliers, noting the agent's habit of repeatedly re-searching when a budget is not met. Muse reached the top of the US App Store this week and took 2.5 million American downloads in a fortnight. For a 24-room camp whose channel manager prices by transaction volume, that is not an abstraction. It is a line item that grows while the booking count does not.

None of this lands in a vacuum, and the contrast with what Kenya has actually bought is instructive. On 29 May the Ministry of Tourism and Wildlife signed a partnership with Google built on four components: a Tourism Pulse data hub on Google Cloud tracking search trends and brand sentiment, a Gemini trip planner that builds itineraries from a traveller's description, a digital skilling programme for tourism SMEs, and targeted advertising in priority markets. Rebecca Miano, the Cabinet Secretary, framed the deal as positioning Kenya as Africa's leading AI-first tourism destination, against a target of roughly 5 million international visitors from 2.7 million in 2025.

Read that alongside this week and a gap opens. Kenya's deal sits almost entirely on the inspiration layer, the part of the funnel where a traveller decides whether to come. Muse and its competitors operate on the layer where the traveller decides who gets paid. Those are different layers, owned by different companies, and only the second one carries margin.

The gap is not theoretical, because the booking layer was already contested before Meta arrived. Google confirmed on 7 August that it was testing agentic hotel booking in the United States through Ask Maps, returning real prices and availability rather than ranges, with Amadeus as technical partner, and was explicit that it would not itself become the commercial operator of the transaction. Julie Farago, its vice-president of travel engineering and local search, had set out the ambition in November 2025 as letting users "describe what they're looking for, compare options, then refine their criteria". In every one of these designs the property is represented by somebody else's connectivity.

The first-order cost of that is already on the record. "I do believe that some of the changes that were made in the display at Google definitely put some pressure on SEO," Glenn Fogel, chief executive of Booking Holdings, told analysts on 4 August, attributing the weakness to AI Overviews. If the company spending billions a year on paid search is losing organic ground to AI summaries, the East African lodge relying on a WordPress site and a decade of blog posts lost it some time ago.

Not everyone believes the agent wins, and the sceptic's case is worth taking seriously even though it does not help. On Wednesday, as her own company's shares fell on its Muse announcement, Ariane Gorin, Expedia's chief executive, told Skift: "I certainly personally don't believe that a large portion of bookings are going to be an end-to-end conversational experience." Expedia has abandoned its own single unified agent for specialised point agents handling discrete parts of planning, and now integrates with Muse, Google's AI Mode, ChatGPT, Claude and Alexa, judging each case on its merits. Its AI tools have not yet lifted booking volume, though the company reports 60 per cent more traveller intent data, higher engagement and lower cancellation rates among travellers who book after using them.

Gorin is probably right about the near term. She is also, read from Nairobi, making the case for the OTA rather than against the agent. Her stated value proposition is fulfilment, customer service, payments, supplier connectivity, inventory breadth and bundling: precisely the reasons a booking should route through Expedia rather than to the hotel. Fogel has made the mirror argument, observing that the vast majority of Booking.com's room nights come from independent hotels while the ten largest global chains account for only a low double-digit

percentage. East Africa's supply is overwhelmingly independent. When the platforms describe whom they protect, they are describing us, and the protection has always carried a price.

The demand, meanwhile, is not the problem. UN Tourism's barometer, published on 15 September, put global arrivals up 0.4 per cent in the first half of 2026, 690 million travellers, three million more than the same period last year. Africa grew 4 per cent, the strongest of any world region, with sub-Saharan Africa at 6 per cent. The visitors are coming. The contest is over who stands between them and the room.

Very little of the useful response involves buying software. Three things are worth doing while the commission question is still open. The first is to know which listings the agents are reading. Muse shops consumer OTA sites, not your booking engine, and Expedia's tie-up entrenches that. If your channel manager pushes clean, current rates and availability to the specific sites an agent browses, you are visible; if a room type is stale on one of them, you are invisible to a shopper you will never know existed. That is a connectivity audit, not a purchase, and it costs an afternoon.

The second is to start measuring look-to-book rather than conversion alone. If your channel or booking engine contract prices by transaction or by API call, agentic shopping transfers cost to you before it transfers revenue. Take the baseline this quarter, while the volumes are small and the rollout is still American. You cannot negotiate a term you have not measured.

The third is to treat your own site as machine-readable infrastructure rather than a brochure. When an agent does look direct, it reads structured data: rates, availability, location, policies, in a form software can parse. Most East African lodge sites carry none. It is cheap, it is durable, and unlike everything else in this story it sits entirely within an owner's control.

One detail deserves a closing moment. Muse is live in the United States only, on iOS, Android, muse.ai and WhatsApp. That last surface is the channel through which an enormous share of East African properties already take enquiries, confirm transfers and chase deposits. The agent Meta has built runs there. The rollout has not reached us, but the shopfront has been installed in our market for years, and Meta owns both ends of it.

The market's verdict on Wednesday looked like a judgement on middlemen. It was not. It was a judgement on who owns the guest, and Expedia had just told everyone the answer. For a camp in the Mara the practical translation is narrower and harder: a new intermediary has arrived, it works for the traveller, it buys from the platform you already pay, and it does not sleep.

BIG READ 9 OF 10 · 26 SEPTEMBER 2026

## Ethiopia's north went dark in a night. East Africa's exposure is the map, not the airport.

*Tigrayan forces took three airports on 23 September and Washington now tells Americans to leave Amhara, Tigray and Afar; for East Africa's hotels the risk is not Addis Ababa's hub but the itinerary, the buyer's map and a neighbourhood that is getting louder.*

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The taxi driver was waiting for a fare at Mekelle's airport when the fighters arrived. They carried light weapons, he told the Associated Press, and ordered him to leave because no flights would land. He heard no gunfire. By the afternoon of 23 September, Ethiopian Airlines, the only carrier flying scheduled services into Tigray, had suspended its flights to Mekelle, Axum and Shire. "We sincerely apologize to our customers for any inconvenience caused by this suspension of flights," the airline said. "We will inform you once flight operations resume."

Nothing in that statement would trouble a lodge owner in the Mara or a hotelier in Stone Town. The Tigray routes are short domestic hops, flown with Dash 8 turboprops to Axum and Shire and Boeing 737s to Mekelle, according to AeroTime. They are not the aircraft that carry a German couple to Kilimanjaro. But the airports were a symptom, and the condition behind them reaches East Africa's order books by routes most operators have not yet mapped.

The sequence took less than a week. On Sunday 20 September the Tigray People's Liberation Front announced an alliance with six other armed groups, among them the Fano militia in Amhara, with the declared aim of overthrowing Prime Minister Abiy Ahmed's government. On the Wednesday the airports went. Getachew Reda, an adviser to the prime minister and himself a former TPLF leader, wrote on X that the front had "taken over federally controlled airports in Tigray leading to the suspension of flights to and from Tigray." He added: "The TPLF politico-military leadership has obviously taken irresponsibility to new heights." Tigray's regional government told a different story. Its forces, it said, were answering "intensive bombardments" by "aircraft, drones, and artillery", and had "entered into a defensive battle."

By Thursday Ethiopian had reportedly also stopped flying to Lalibela in Amhara, where Reuters had reported federal forces firing heavy weapons from a camp in the town. On Friday 25 September the US Embassy in Addis Ababa issued the sentence that matters most to anyone who sells travel. "U.S. citizens are advised not to travel to the Amhara Region (including Lalibela), the Tigray Region, or the Afar Region for any reason," it said, and those already there should "leave if it is safe to do so or shelter in place." Canada's foreign ministry said it was "disturbed by the seizure of the Mekelle airport and the telecom blackout." London had moved a day earlier. The Foreign Office's advice, updated on 24 September and read directly for this article, now warns against all travel to the parts of Afar within 50km of the Tigray boundary and 20km of the Eritrean border, and against all but essential travel to the rest of Afar. That sits on top of standing advice against all travel to Tigray and to Amhara.

Diplomats reached for the language of alarm. Mahmoud Ali Youssouf, chairperson of the African Union Commission, said the seizure and occupation of "the civilian airports of Mekelle, Axum, and Shire by Tigray forces" was inconsistent with the Pretoria Agreement of 2022 and risked "eroding the hard-won gains achieved in the pursuit of lasting peace and stability." He asked Olusegun Obasanjo, the former Nigerian president, to engage the parties urgently. The stakes are not abstract. The last war, from 2020 to 2022, killed about 600,000 people by African Union estimates, and about a million people in the north remain displaced.

The regional dimension is what should make East Africans sit up. Billene Seyoum, the prime minister's spokesperson, told Reuters that the new alliance had been working with financial backing from Eritrea, which has repeatedly denied such accusations. Alan Boswell, Horn of Africa director at the International Crisis Group, pointed to Eritrea's closeness to Sudan's army and to Ethiopia's own souring relations with it. "So this is all

becoming one big regional mess," he told Al Jazeera, "and it could get very, very ugly if we don't see de-escalation." Ethiopia's president, Taye Atske-Selassie, used the United Nations General Assembly to send the opposite message. "Our message to forces of destruction and mayhem is loud and clear," he said, urging them to respect the right of the Horn's people "to live in peace and prosperity."

The instinctive East African question is about the hub. Addis Ababa is home to Ethiopian Airlines and one of the doors through which long-haul guests reach Entebbe, Kigali, Kilimanjaro and Zanzibar. It is also, for now, the question with the most reassuring answer. Nothing in this week's notices touches the capital or Bole International. The British map, which lists in painstaking detail the Ethiopian regions, zones and border strips to avoid, carves out the corridors around Addis Ababa, including the expressway to Adama and ten kilometres either side of the road to Bishoftu. The suspensions Ethiopian announced cover northern domestic points. When the airline does change its long-haul network, it tends to do so for commercial reasons that owners should be tracking anyway: this publication reported on 23 September that the Addis Ababa to Chicago service, routed via Rome, will drop to five flights a week from 18 January.

That is the misread. The exposure for East African hotels does not run through the runway at Bole. It runs through three other channels, and each of them is already live.

The first is the itinerary. Lalibela's rock-hewn churches and the stelae of Axum are UNESCO World Heritage sites, and both now sit behind the warnings. For British travellers that chapter was already closed on paper, since the Foreign Office had advised against all travel to Amhara before this week, and its own pages warn that travelling against its advice can invalidate insurance. What changed is that the aircraft stopped and Washington used the words "for any reason". Wherever an agent has paired Lalibela or Axum with a safari further south, the Ethiopian leg is now unsellable for the season, and the nights it held are looking for a home.

This is the part of the story nobody in the East African trade has yet said aloud. The obvious substitutes for a heritage chapter are on the Swahili coast. Stone Town in Zanzibar and Lamu Old Town are both World Heritage sites, both a short flight from the safari circuit. And by a coincidence of timing, on 25 September France redrew its map of Kenya. The Quai d'Orsay's security page, updated that day and read directly for this article, now places the islands of Lamu and Manda in its lowest band, "vigilance renforcée", with access by air only. On the map France had used since March, and which this publication carried until this week, the Lamu archipelago sat in orange. Paris did not move because of Ethiopia. But an agent re-routing a displaced week this autumn will find Lamu cleaner on the French map than at any point since at least March.

The second channel is the buyer's map, and here the news is less comfortable. Advisories bleed across borders in the mind of the person who signs off a trip. Kenya's frontier with Ethiopia already sits inside every major government's no-go zones: Britain advises against all travel within 10km of the Kenyan border on the Ethiopian side, and the US keeps the parts of Marsabit and Turkana within 50km of Ethiopia at Level 4, its highest. A duty-of-care officer at a European company or charity now sees "Ethiopia" and "fighting" in the same week that France keeps an active pre-electoral warning on Kenya, published on 11 September, ahead of the general election on 10 August 2027. The same officer may also have read the US Embassy in Nairobi's security alert of 25 September, which warned of a possible breach of personal data collected during Ebola screening at Kenya's ports of entry. "The U.S. Embassy is unable to confirm if an individual's data is part of the breach," it said. Among those potentially affected, according to the alert as reported by Kenyans.co.ke, is anyone who entered Kenya from Ethiopia since screening began in late May.

None of these items is large on its own. Together they describe a Horn of Africa that sounds louder than the booking data may justify, and Nairobi's conference and corporate trade lives on precisely those sign-offs. The advisories themselves did not move for Kenya this week. The British, American, Canadian and German advice on Kenya was unchanged when read directly on 26 September. That is a fact sales teams should be able to state in one sentence, with the dates, before a client asks.

The third channel is time. The peace that brought flights back to Tigray was slow to translate into air service:

Ethiopian resumed Addis Ababa to Mekelle on 28 December 2022, weeks after the Pretoria deal, and daily flights to Axum returned only on 9 June 2024, after repairs to the airfield and terminal, according to AeroTime. If the pattern holds, a new war in the north is measured in seasons, not weeks. East African operators should plan on that basis rather than on a quick return to normal.

For owners, the conclusions are practical rather than dramatic. City hotels in Nairobi, Kampala and Kigali should brief their sales and reservations teams tonight with a short, dated statement: which Ethiopian regions are affected, that Addis Ababa and Bole sit outside every warning issued this week, and that the major advisories on their own country did not change. Beach properties in Lamu, Zanzibar and along the Kenyan coast should get in front of the specialists who sell Ethiopia's north, with heritage nights priced for the displaced week, not the peak. Safari camps with guests routing through Addis Ababa need do nothing yet but watch, and they should know what they are watching for.

Three indicators will tell the story. The first is any change to the British or American language on Addis Ababa itself, or on Bole. The second is any Ethiopian Airlines notice that reaches beyond the northern domestic points into its regional or long-haul network. The third is whether Obasanjo's mission produces direct talks, or whether the AU's warning about neighbours joining the escalation proves to have been the more accurate forecast.

The war in Ethiopia's north will not close East Africa's front door. It will test whether the region's hotels can tell their buyers, precisely and quickly, which doors are still open.

BIG READ 10 OF 10 · 27 SEPTEMBER 2026

## Uganda's Ebola all-clear was not an event. It was a queue, and Friday was the first name off it.

*The World Health Organization closed Uganda's outbreak on 26 August. The United Arab Emirates lifted its entry curbs on 26 September. Washington's suspension order was renewed on 11 September and still lists a country with no cases. For East African operators the lesson is that clearance is not declared, it is negotiated, one government at a time.*

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On Friday, Kampala finally got the answer it had been chasing since the start of June. The United Arab Emirates, which on 6 June had stopped issuing new visas to Ugandan nationals and told anyone travelling from Uganda to prove they had spent 21 days somewhere else first, said the measures were being eased. Adonia Ayebare, who had been working the file for Uganda, described the exchange without ornament. "His Highness informed me of the decision to lift travel restrictions on Uganda, subject to a delegation of UAE visiting the Uganda Civil Aviation Authority and other entities to assess preparedness," he said. Emirati precautions against the Democratic Republic of Congo and South Sudan stay in force.

The announcement matters, but the date matters more. The World Health Organization declared Uganda's Ebola outbreak over on 26 August, after 42 days without a new case, against a final total of 20 confirmed infections, two deaths and 18 recoveries. Uganda's own health ministry had declared local transmission ended a month before that, on 28 July. So the gap between the moment Uganda's epidemiological file closed and the moment its single most important aviation and labour corridor reopened was exactly one month. The gap between the health ministry's declaration and Friday was two.

That interval, not the outbreak, is the commercial story, and it is the one every hotel and lodge owner in the region should be reading. A country does not get cleared once. It gets cleared repeatedly, by different governments, working from different instruments, on clocks that have nothing to do with each other and very little to do with case counts. The all-clear is not an event. It is a queue, and until Friday nobody had moved.

Uganda now has a number for what the queue costs. The Uganda Civil Aviation Authority's August traffic report, released on 18 September, recorded 169,706 international passengers through Entebbe. That is 8.5 per cent better than July's 156,342, which is the recovery everyone wanted to see. It is also 29.1 per cent below the 239,329 passengers the airport handled in August 2025, a shortfall of 69,623 people in the strongest travel month of the year. Arrivals were 88,270 against 81,436 departures. KLM, which suspended its Entebbe service during the outbreak, had still not returned.

August was a month in which Uganda recorded no Ebola case and held a WHO all-clear from the 26th. The traffic gap is therefore not the price of an outbreak. It is the price of a label, and the label was still attached.

Set that against the same month on the other side of the region. Zanzibar recorded 124,481 international arrivals in August, an all-time monthly record, up around 18 per cent year on year. Same region, same month, same very large outbreak in the Democratic Republic of Congo next door. One destination was named in other governments' live instruments. The other was not. Nothing epidemiological separated them.

The reason the month passed the way it did is that "travel restrictions" is a plural noun pretending to be a singular one. Uganda was carrying at least four distinct constraints, each held by a different authority.

The heaviest is American and it is not an advisory at all. The US Centers for Disease Control and Prevention operates an order suspending the entry of foreign nationals who have been physically present in the DRC, Uganda or South Sudan in the previous 21 days. It was first issued on 18 May. It was reissued on 11 September,

for a further 30 days, on the stated basis that the measure "is necessary to protect the health of the United States from the serious risk posed by the introduction of Ebola disease". That renewal came sixteen days after the WHO closed Uganda's outbreak, and it named Uganda anyway.

Alongside it sit the CDC's travel health notices, which as of the agency's 23 September update placed Ituri and Nord-Kivu at Level 4, Haut-Uele and Tshopo at Level 3, and the rest of the DRC together with Uganda at Level 2. And above both sits the State Department's country advisory, which in early August was still at Level 4, Do Not Travel, for Uganda, the DRC and South Sudan. "Our Travel Advisory for the DRC, as well as those for Uganda and South Sudan, remains at Level 4," the department said then, a week after Uganda had declared transmission over. Tommy Pigott, its spokesman, framed the logic as containment at source: "From the outset, our objective has been clear: Protect Americans, contain the outbreak at its source, and support affected countries."

Each of those instruments has its own trigger, its own review cycle and its own author. An operator watching for "the restrictions to lift" is watching a thing that does not exist. What exists is a set of locks, and the keys are held in different buildings.

Kampala's objection has been consistent and it is worth taking seriously, because it is an argument about the unit of analysis rather than about the science. Dr Jean Kaseya, director-general of Africa CDC, put it at its sharpest. "We don't need double standards. And as an African leader, I clearly say no double standard. If there is no travel restriction to France, there is no travel restriction to Uganda." The comparison is not rhetorical: the WHO's own case tally for this outbreak includes one case in France.

Uganda's health minister, Dr Chris Baryomunsi, was blunter still. "The US Canada, UAE, who put travel restrictions, that decision is not backed by science from those figures. It's out of fear." Dr Diana Atwine, the health ministry's permanent secretary, made the ask directly on the day the WHO declaration landed. "Unless they have other reasons, they should definitely lift the restrictions off the country, and Ugandans should be free to travel to any country."

The WHO's formal position supports them. In its 10 September update on the outbreak the organisation repeated that it "advises against any restriction of travel to, or trade with, affected countries".

None of which means the restricting governments are acting on nothing. The DRC outbreak is the second largest on record and it is still running. The WHO's 10 September figures put it at 6,757 confirmed cases and 3,267 deaths, a case fatality ratio of 48.3 per cent, across six provinces and 61 health zones. By 15 September the count had reached 7,258 cases and 3,510 deaths. "The epidemic continues to grow and continues to kill," Dr Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus said on 16 September, while allowing that cooperation had improved.

So the honest description of what is happening is not that rich governments are inventing a risk. It is that they are managing a genuine sub-national emergency with a country-level tool, and country-level tools cannot distinguish between Ituri and Rubirizi. Shaun Stanley, founder of Stanley Safaris, made the point early in the outbreak and it has aged well. "Africa is not a single place, and an outbreak in a remote province of the DRC is no more a reason to cancel a gorilla trek in Rwanda than an outbreak in one part of Europe would be a reason to cancel a trip to another. Context is everything."

Rwanda is the clearest illustration. It was moved to Level 3, Reconsider Travel, on 19 May, on the strength of geography rather than a case of its own.

The operators felt the instruments before the statisticians measured them. Lydia Eva Mpanga of Nkuringo Bwindi Lodge described the mechanism in June: "Travellers are cancelling and some are postponing because of the travel advisories." Isaac Kato, vice-president of the Uganda Tourism Association, reported that "several tourism bookings have been cancelled, some events have been postponed and hotel occupancy rates have dropped sharply", while noting the fact that never quite travelled as fast: "No cases have been traced to tourists visiting Uganda's attractions, hotels, conferences or tourism events."

Jean Byamugisha, chief executive of the Uganda Hotel Owners Association, called the restrictions "uncalled-for" and asked why Uganda alone among the DRC's neighbours had collected every level of advisory. The airlines followed the paperwork rather than the epidemiology. KLM, flydubai and Air Arabia withdrew; Emirates kept flying but, as Olive Lumonya, the aviation authority's deputy director general, put it, "they are more or less taking in only transit passengers, not people who are coming in from Uganda". Her second remark is the one to keep: "It is coming in at a time when we are under pressure to create confidence and trust in Uganda."

The practical conclusion is not that operators should lobby harder. It is that they should stop treating clearance as a date and start treating it as a schedule.

Three things follow. First, a property's real risk register is not a list of diseases or conflicts. It is a list of the live legal instruments in other countries that name yours, with the authority that holds each one and the date it next comes up for review. Uganda's was four items long in August, and knowing that would have told a Ugandan lodge that the WHO declaration bought it no immediate volume from North America.

Second, the lag is forecastable enough to budget. Uganda spent a month between clearance and its first major reopening, and its traffic is climbing at about 8.5 per cent a month from a 29 per cent hole, which puts August 2025's level four clean months away. That is a financial-year assumption, not a press release. Build the 2027 plan off the recovery curve rather than off the all-clear.

Third, the next decision point is already on the calendar. The American suspension order runs 30 days from 11 September, which means it lapses or renews around the middle of October. Friday proved that these instruments do come off. It also proved they come off one at a time, after a delegation visits, and in an order set by diplomacy.

The stakes are not marginal. Uganda's tourism ministry reported this week that the country drew 1.6 million visitors in 2025, earning UGX 5.8 trillion, about USD 1.62 billion, at an average of USD 986 a visitor over 8.8 nights, worth 5.9 per cent of GDP and supporting 876,000 jobs. Against that base, a single peak month running 29 per cent light is not a rounding error, and it was incurred with a clean bill of health in hand.

The uncomfortable lesson for Nairobi, Arusha, Kigali and Zanzibar is that none of this was earned or avoidable by good public health practice. Uganda did the epidemiology well: 20 cases, two deaths, a 42-day countdown completed without incident. It still lost a season, because clearance is not declared by the country that achieves it. It is granted, slowly, by everybody else.

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**THE LEDGER**

*We publish our forecasts with resolution criteria and a deadline, then score them in public. Open calls can be checked against the source on the date given.*

**RESOLVED THIS WEEK****P002 · CORRECT**

The US State Department will NOT lower Uganda from Level 4 within 30 days of the outbreak being declared over

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**P130 · CORRECT**

WHO's 26 August 2026 certification that Uganda is Ebola-free will NOT be followed by any change to Uganda's US State Department travel advisory LEVEL within 30 days — the Level 4 was set on 17 May 2026 on the stated ground of the Bundibugyo outbreak in Ituri Province, DRC, which is still growing

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**P156 · CORRECT**

No East African national tourism board or trade body (KTB, Tanzania Tourist Board, Uganda Tourism Board, RDB, Zanzibar Commission for Tourism, KATO, TATO, AUTO, ZATI, RTTA, East African Tourism Platform) will publish EmpCo-specific member guidance BEFORE the directive's application date of 27 September 2026 — the tighter test on P144's 31 January 2027 window

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**P173 · CORRECT**

WHO will publish at least one further DRC Bundibugyo Disease Outbreak News on or before 31 October 2026 reporting more than 7,000 cumulative confirmed DRC cases - DON616 carried 5,794 to 26 Aug and the DRC's own SitRep 116 already reported 6,686 on 8 Sep

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**P178 · INCORRECT**

WHO will NOT add South-Ubangi to the official list of DRC provinces affected by the Bundibugyo outbreak on or before 31 October 2026 - the acting governor's 11 Sep case is an imported death with no confirmed local transmission, and 38 contacts were quarantined immediately

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**P185 · CORRECT**

WHO's next Bundibugyo Disease Outbreak News for the DRC will report the affected-province count at SEVEN or more, confirming the seven-province figure ECDC carried on 14 September 2026 against WHO's own six-province count in DON617 of 10 September 2026

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